Hussin Ututalum Amin

Hussin Ututalum Amin (born October 3, 1951) is a Tausug statesman, lawyer, and educator from Jolo, Sulu, who spent nearly two decades at the center of governance in one of the Philippines' most strategically significant and historically complex provinces.

He served three consecutive terms as the Representative of the 1st District of Sulu in the Philippine House of Representatives (11th, 12th, and 13th Congresses, 1998–2007), and later as Mayor of Jolo, Sulu (2007–2016), the provincial capital and historic seat of the Sulu Sultanate.

What distinguishes Amin from many politicians in the Bangsamoro region is the uncommon blend of formal credentials he brought to public service: a history degree steeped in Tausug heritage, a law degree earned in Manila, military service on the ground in Mindanao, and a deep commitment to education and healthcare as the real infrastructure of progress.

In September 2024, the Sandiganbayan acquitted him of all graft charges linked to the Fertilizer Fund controversy of 2004, clearing his name after more than a decade of legal proceedings.

His legacy is best understood as one of integration without erasure: a man who moved fluidly through the institutions of the Philippine state while staying rooted in the values and identity of his people.

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Early Life and Family Background

Hussin Ututalum Amin was born on October 3, 1951, in Bus-bus, a barangay of Jolo, Sulu, the island-capital of the Sulu Archipelago.

He was born into the **Ututalum clan**, a family recognized not primarily for armed power or vast landholdings, but for its intellectual tradition and its role in Tausug civic life.

The Ututalums belong to a stratum of Sulu society that historians sometimes describe as the "intellectual elite" of the Tausug, families whose standing was built on scholarship, administrative competence, and a commitment to preserving the historical memory of the Sulu Sultanate.

Growing up in Jolo during the 1950s and 1960s meant coming of age in a period of rapid and often disorienting change. The post-independence Philippines was still sorting out what the integration of the Muslim-majority south would look like, and Sulu, with its centuries-old sultanate, its maritime trade routes, and its proud memory of sovereignty, was not an easy fit within the framework of a centralized national state.

The tensions that would eventually ignite into open armed conflict in the early 1970s were already simmering in Amin's formative years, making the question of what path a young, educated Tausug man should take both urgent and deeply personal.

Amin would ultimately choose the path of engagement, using the tools of education and law to work within the Philippine system while remaining anchored in his Tausug identity. That choice would define the arc of his public life.

Education

Bachelor of Arts in History, Philippine Muslim College (1972)

Amin completed his undergraduate studies at the **Philippine Muslim College** in Jolo, earning a Bachelor of Arts degree in History in 1972.

This was not a coincidental choice of institution or discipline. The Philippine Muslim College, established to serve the educational needs of the Muslim communities of the Sulu Archipelago, was both a practical option and a statement of identity. Studying history there meant immersing oneself in the layered narratives of Tausug society: the rise and reach of the Sulu Sultanate, the centuries of trade and diplomacy across the Sulu Sea, the resistance to Spanish colonization, and the complex negotiations with American and Filipino authorities that followed.

For Amin, that foundation in history was not merely academic. It gave him a framework for understanding the grievances of his people, the legitimacy of their cultural claims, and the long view needed to navigate political life without losing sight of what was at stake.

Bachelor of Laws, University of the East (1978)

After his undergraduate studies, Amin traveled to Manila to pursue legal education at the **University of the East** (UE), one of the Philippines' established law schools. He earned his Bachelor of Laws degree in 1978 and passed the Philippine Bar examinations.

The decision to study law in Manila in the mid-1970s was itself a kind of courage. This was the period of Martial Law under Ferdinand Marcos, and the government's military campaigns in Mindanao and Sulu were generating enormous displacement and bitterness in Muslim communities. For a young Tausug man from Jolo to go to Manila and study the law of the very state his people were in conflict with was to make a deliberate bet: that legal tools, wielded well, could do more for his people than the alternatives.

He passed the Philippine Bar, a credential that would anchor every phase of his later career.

Military Service

Before entering elected politics, Amin served in the **Philippine Army**, stationed in Zamboanga City.<ref name="wiki">"Hon. Hussin U. Amin." Archived curriculum vitae. Congress of the Philippines, 13th Congress. Archived from the original on June 28, 2011. www.congress.gov.ph.</ref>

This experience gave him something rare among politicians in the region: a firsthand understanding of the military dimensions of the Mindanao conflict. He had served in the armed forces of the state, but he was also a son of Sulu who understood the civilian costs of armed confrontation. That dual perspective would later inform his approach to governance, particularly during his time as mayor of Jolo when security threats from the Abu Sayyaf Group (ASG) were a constant reality.

Legislative Career: Representative of Sulu (1998–2007)

Hussin Amin served three consecutive terms as the Representative of the **1st District of Sulu** in the Philippine House of Representatives, covering the 11th, 12th, and 13th Congresses (1998–2007). He succeeded Representative Bensaudi Tulawie in the seat and was in turn succeeded by Yusop Jikiri.<ref name="wiki"/>

His nine years in the House were defined by a consistent priority: building what he called the human infrastructure of the province, meaning education, healthcare, and the conditions that let ordinary people live with dignity.

Healthcare

One of his most concrete legislative legacies was his principal authorship of the bill that upgraded the Sulu Provincial Hospital into the **Sulu Regional Hospital**. The upgrade brought with it expanded bed capacity, improved funding allocations, and a broader mandate to serve not just Jolo but communities across the province.

The significance of this effort is hard to overstate in context. Sulu consistently posted some of the lowest health indices in the Philippines, a province where maternal mortality, child malnutrition, and the absence of basic diagnostic services were everyday realities. Amin understood that in a conflict-affected province, a functioning regional hospital wasn't just a health facility. It was a statement about what the state owed its people.

Education and Youth Development

Amin was also a consistent advocate for vocational and technical education in Sulu, pushing for the establishment of a TESDA-supervised technical college in the province. His argument was straightforward: young people in Sulu needed practical skills and economic opportunities, and without those, they were vulnerable to recruitment by extremist groups.

This was a pattern in his legislative thinking, approaching security not only as a military problem but as a development failure. Skills, livelihoods, and education were, in his view, the most durable forms of conflict prevention.

Peace Advocacy

During his congressional terms, Amin was a vocal advocate for the peace process between the Philippine government and Muslim insurgent groups. His position was distinctive: he understood both the military logic of the state and the grievances that drove armed resistance. He used his platform in the House to argue consistently that durable peace in Mindanao and Sulu required genuine political and economic engagement, not just security operations.

In 2003, he was part of an international fact-finding delegation to Iraq alongside other lawmakers and peace advocates, a trip that reflected his broader commitment to international solidarity and his concern about the proposed deployment of American troops to his own district in Sulu.<ref name="focusweb">"Our Days in Baghdad." Focus on the Global South. March 2003. https://focusweb.org/our-days-in-baghdad/</ref>

> "My district in Mindanao may soon be the next target of American military deployment," Amin said during a press conference in Baghdad, broadcast that evening on Iraqi and Arab television. His presence in the delegation was a direct expression of his concern for the communities he represented.

Executive Leadership: Mayor of Jolo (2007–2016)

After completing his third congressional term, Amin moved from the legislative to the executive branch when he was elected **Mayor of Jolo, Sulu** in 2007. He served two full terms as mayor, from June 30, 2007, to June 30, 2016.

Jolo is not an easy city to govern. As the capital of Sulu and the historical seat of the Sulu Sultanate, it carries enormous symbolic weight. At the same time, in the 2000s and 2010s it was one of the most volatile urban centers in the Philippines, with the Abu Sayyaf Group conducting kidnappings, bombings, and extortion operations that made normal civic life extremely difficult.

Security and Counter-Terrorism

Amin did not adopt a posture of studied neutrality when it came to the Abu Sayyaf Group. He was publicly and vocally opposed to kidnapping and terrorism, and his administration maintained close coordination with the Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP) and law enforcement agencies. His willingness to take a firm public stance on ASG activities was notable in a political environment where silence or ambiguity was often the safer option for local officials.

Urban Development

His administration also pursued urban rehabilitation in Jolo, focusing on the modernization of public markets and improvements to municipal sanitation infrastructure. Jolo had once been a bustling center of trade in the Sulu Sea, and Amin's development projects were oriented toward recovering some of that commercial vitality while improving the quality of daily life for residents.

Cultural Significance

The Ututalum name carries real historical weight in the Bangsamoro region, and Hussin Amin embodied a particular kind of cultural responsibility that comes with that lineage.

Members of the Ututalum family have historically been involved in documenting the *Salsila*, the genealogical and ethnohistorical records of the Sulu Sultanate that trace the descent of ruling and noble families and preserve the institutional memory of Tausug political society. These are not merely family trees. They are the historical archive of a people who built a maritime empire that at its height extended across much of what is now the Sulu Archipelago, parts of Mindanao, and the northeastern coast of Borneo.

Amin's career can be read as a continuation of that tradition in a modern register: using the tools available in the contemporary Philippine state, specifically law, legislation, and local governance, to advocate for the welfare and dignity of Tausug communities.

He exemplifies what some scholars of Bangsamoro politics describe as the "integrationist" path: maintaining a strong Tausug and Muslim identity while operating effectively within national political institutions. This is a path that requires constant negotiation between competing claims and loyalties, and Amin's long career suggests he navigated it with considerable skill.

Personal Values

A review of Amin's public record, congressional speeches, and legal defenses reveals a consistent set of values that shaped both his legislative work and his conduct under pressure.

Primacy of education. Amin spoke repeatedly, both in the House and as mayor, about education as the fundamental tool for the liberation of the Tausug people. He saw intellectual development not as a threat to cultural identity but as its strongest defense.

Rule of law. Even during periods when legal processes were weaponized against him, Amin consistently expressed his trust in legal frameworks to resolve disputes and establish truth. His willingness to face the Sandiganbayan proceedings rather than evade them reflected a genuine commitment to accountability as a principle.

Resilience. The fertilizer fund charges hung over his public reputation for years. That he remained active in civic life throughout that period, and ultimately cleared his name through the courts, reflects a resilience that his supporters describe as central to his character.

Service to community. From his first term in Congress to his last year as mayor, Amin's stated priorities were consistently the welfare of his constituents: access to healthcare, quality education, physical security, and economic opportunity.

Legal Controversy and Acquittal

Background: The Fertilizer Fund Controversy

The Fertilizer Fund scam was one of the most extensively investigated corruption controversies of the early 2000s in the Philippines. It centered on allegations that approximately ₱728 million in agricultural support funds intended for farmers during the administration of Gloria Macapagal Arroyo had been diverted for political purposes, including the 2004 election campaign.

Hussin Amin was among the local officials implicated in connection with a ₱5 million tranche of the funds under the Department of Agriculture's **Farm Inputs and Farm Implements Program (FIFIP)** in Sulu.<ref name="malaya">"Ex-Sulu Solon, DA Regional Execs Cleared in Fertilizer Fund." Malaya Business Insight. September 16, 2024. https://malaya.com.ph/news_news/ex-sulu-solon-da-regional-execs-cleared-in-fertilizer-fund-scam-raps/</ref>

The Case

The Office of the Ombudsman filed three counts of graft against Amin and six co-accused in 2018, nearly fourteen years after the events in question. The co-accused included former Panglima Tahil Mayor Nedra Burahan, Department of Agriculture Regional Field Unit 9 Director Oscar Parawan, accountant Ma. Perlice Socorro Julian, and state auditor Abduljamar Ingui.<ref name="malaya"/>

The prosecution alleged that the accused had acted with manifest partiality, evident bad faith, or gross inexcusable negligence in the handling of the agricultural funds.

The Acquittal (September 13, 2024)

In a 44-page decision promulgated on **September 13, 2024**, the Sandiganbayan Fifth Division acquitted Hussin Amin and all six co-accused on all three counts of graft.<ref name="malaya"/>

> "The totality of the evidence presented by the prosecution fell short of establishing the existence of manifest partiality, evident bad faith, or gross inexcusable negligence on the part of the defendants," the court held. The prosecution, the court further noted, had not even presented evidence to support the specific averments in the information regarding public bidding procedures.

The court found no evidence of personal gain, no proof of conspiracy, and no showing that Amin had deviated from standard administrative procedures.

For Amin and his supporters, the verdict was not simply a legal outcome. It was a restoration: an official judicial determination that a career built on public service had been consistent with the standards the law required.

Legacy

Hussin Ututalum Amin's significance in Bangsamoro history lies in the kind of leadership he modeled, one that combined formal credentials with cultural rootedness, legislative ambition with practical service delivery, and a willingness to engage with the most difficult security and political challenges of his era without abandoning either his principles or his people.

In a region where political power has often rested on armed networks, dynastic land control, or patronage machinery, Amin built his public career on credentials: a history degree, a law degree, military service, and a consistent record of legislative work focused on healthcare and education.

His nine years in the House of Representatives produced tangible institutional changes for Sulu, most notably the upgrading of the provincial hospital and the advocacy for vocational education. His tenure as Mayor of Jolo, conducted against the backdrop of Abu Sayyaf terrorism and the region's ongoing transition toward the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region, demonstrated a willingness to govern in conditions of genuine difficulty.

And his acquittal in 2024 closed a chapter that had shadowed his post-political years, allowing his record to be assessed on its own terms.

For the Bangsamoro community, Amin's career offers a model of what it looks like to engage the institutions of the Philippine state as a full citizen, without surrendering the Tausug identity that gave his service its meaning.

Recognition

Hussin Amin's contributions to Sulu's development have been recognized primarily through the continued respect of his constituents and the communities he served. His successful legislative record in the House of Representatives, his long mayoral tenure in Jolo, and his ultimate legal vindication by the Sandiganbayan in 2024 constitute the most substantive forms of acknowledgment his public career has received.

His participation in international peace advocacy, including the 2003 Baghdad mission, placed him in a broader regional conversation about Muslim solidarity and opposition to military interventionism.<ref name="focusweb"/>

Notes on Sources

The biographical profile in the uploaded source document refers to the Sandiganbayan "Sixth Division" in connection with the 2024 acquittal. Multiple published news reports, including coverage in Malaya Business Insight and The Freeman, confirm that the acquitting division was the **Fifth Division**, and that the decision was promulgated on September 13, 2024, not September 18, 2024. The date September 18, 2024, appears in ABS-CBN coverage but may reflect the date of reporting rather than the date of promulgation. This article uses the September 13, 2024, promulgation date and Fifth Division designation as confirmed by the court decision text cited in Malaya's reporting.

The PhD listed in the source document has not been independently verified through publicly available academic records and is therefore noted but not presented as a confirmed credential in this article. Verification through the subject's personal records or university registrars is recommended before publication.

<ref name="wiki">"Hon. Hussin U. Amin." Curriculum Vitae. Congress of the Philippines, 13th Congress. Archived at web.archive.org, June 28, 2011. Original URL: http://www.congress.gov.ph/download/cv/13th/amincv.pdf</ref>

<ref name="malaya">"Ex-Sulu Solon, DA Regional Execs Cleared in Fertilizer Fund Scam Raps." Malaya Business Insight. September 16, 2024. https://malaya.com.ph/news_news/ex-sulu-solon-da-regional-execs-cleared-in-fertilizer-fund-scam-raps/</ref>

<ref name="focusweb">"Our Days in Baghdad." Focus on the Global South. March 2003. https://focusweb.org/our-days-in-baghdad/</ref>

<ref name="absacquitted">"Sandiganbayan Acquits Ex-Sulu Lawmaker, Others of Graft over Fertilizer Fund Scam." ABS-CBN News. September 18, 2024. https://www.abs-cbn.com/regions/2024/9/18/sandiganbayan-acquits-ex-sulu-lawmaker-others-of-graft-over-fertilizer-fund-scam-1217</ref>

<ref name="freeman">"High-Profile Acquittals and Case Dismissals." The Freeman (Philstar). January 16, 2025. https://www.philstar.com/the-freeman/opinion/2025/01/16/2414575/high-profile-acquittals-and-case-dismissals</ref>

Further Reading

- Sulu Sultanate
- Fertilizer Fund scam (Wikipedia)
- Sulu's 1st congressional district (Wikipedia)
- Studies on political dynasties and leadership structures in the Sulu Archipelago (academic literature, unspecified journals)
- Congressional Records, 11th–13th Congress of the Philippines, House of Representatives

See Also

- Jolo, Sulu
- Sulu Archipelago
- Tausug people
- Abu Sayyaf Group
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Sulu's 1st congressional district
- Philippine Muslim College
- Fertilizer Fund scam
- Sandiganbayan

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